

RAPIDO · PAYMENTS

The ride ended. The payment didn't.

Why a failed UPI payment shouldn't turn into a roadside argument — and how I'd design the fix.

● ——— ● ——— ● ——— ● Problem → Root cause → Solution → Metrics

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Swipe →

A viral clip. A familiar problem.

A ride reaches its destination. The passenger reportedly says her bank server is down and she'll pay later. The captain is left to decide what happens next — on the roadside, on camera.

THE OBVIOUS QUESTION

~~Should she pay or not?~~

THE PM QUESTION

Why does the product let a payment failure become a human confrontation?

WHAT ALREADY EXISTS

Rapido's customer terms already say: if online payment can't go through, pay in cash.

The rule exists. The workflow doesn't.

Three users. Three different jobs.

Passenger

PRIMARY

"When my payment fails after a ride, help me finish paying — without confusion and without being charged twice."

Captain

PRIMARY

"Tell me clearly whether I've been paid, and protect my earnings — without making me negotiate with the passenger."

Rapido

PLATFORM

"When a ride ends, make sure the fare is collected, safely marked as due, or routed into a controlled recovery."

The tension: customer convenience ↔ captain protection ↔ fraud prevention.

Where the journey breaks

● Ride completed

● Payment initiated

● **Payment fails / times out / "bank issue"**
The app has no strong state for what happens next

○ "I'll pay later"

○ Captain has to decide alone

○ Conflict → unpaid fare → support ticket

The system is weakest exactly where money and trust meet.

It's not a passenger problem. It's a system gap.

01

Binary payment states

Success/Failed hides Pending, Unknown and Reversed. Treating pending as failed invites a second payment.

02

Captain = collections desk

When the app can't resolve it, two strangers negotiate money on the street.

03

No recovery path

"Payment failed" is a dead end. It should lead to retry → another method → cash → controlled recovery.

04

An easy loophole

If "server is down, I'll pay later" works once, it can be repeated at scale.

Principle: never leave a payment dispute to human negotiation when the platform can resolve it digitally.

Payment Recovery

A flow that starts the moment a ride ends without a confirmed fare.
Step one: know the real state.

SUCCESS

Close the ride, credit the captain

PENDING

Wait for the bank. Don't ask to pay again

FAILED

Retry UPI · another UPI ID · card · cash

UNKNOWN

Reconcile first, then decide

STILL UNPAID? ROUTE BY RISK

Trusted rider

"Payment Due" — settle within a set window

New / high-risk

Settle before the next booking

Same ₹127. Two calm screens.

PASSENGER

We couldn't complete your payment

₹127 due

Retry UPI

Use another UPI ID

Card

Pay captain in cash

If a debit is pending, we'll say "Don't pay again — checking with your bank."

CAPTAIN

Fare status

₹127

Payment pending

Rapido is helping the rider finish.
You can end the trip.

Fare protected

For eligible rides, ₹127 is credited now. Rapido recovers it from the rider.

Report unpaid fare

My addition: a Fare Protection promise — the platform, not the captain, carries the recovery risk.

₹254

for a ₹127 ride.

Rider pays ₹127 by UPI. The bank debits her.

Confirmation is slow. **App says "failed"**.

She pays the captain ₹127 in cash.

An hour later the UPI payment succeeds.

Now she's angry, and she may have been right about the "bank issue" all along.

Never treat Pending as Failed.

Reconcile before asking for a second payment. Not every "failure" is a rider refusing to pay.

Ship small. Measure honestly.

MVP · P0

4-state payment status

Recovery screen

Pending reconciliation

Captain status screen

NEXT · P1-P2

Payment Due balance

Reliability scoring & fraud signals

NORTH STAR

Fare collection rate

rides with fare collected ÷ completed rides

SUPPORTING

Recovery rate · time to resolve · support contacts per ride

GUARDRAILS

Duplicate payments · false blocks · captain churn

WHAT I WOULD NOT BUILD

Penalties for every failed payment — an outage isn't fraud

Forcing cash while UPI is still pending

Unlimited "pay later"

Experiment: A/B the recovery flow on rides with a failed payment. Win = recovery ↑, disputes ↓, duplicates flat.

A payment failure shouldn't become a people problem.

It can be designed as a product workflow.

Passenger: "The app told me exactly what to do."

Captain: "I know I've been paid. No arguing."

Rapido: "We know if it's collected, pending or in recovery."

YOUR TAKE?

Who should carry the risk of an unpaid ride — the captain, the rider, or the platform?

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